

YUAN LONGPING

Chinese agronomist
1930–present



After studying soil and crop science at university, Yuan Longping became a teacher and researcher at a farming college. At first, his research focused on sweet potatoes. However, when a terrible famine in China left millions of people without food, Longping switched to studying rice—the main plant food eaten in China. In 1961, Longping came across a rice plant that had plumper grains than usual. If there were more plants like this, he thought, then more people could be fed.

However, Longping knew that the plant's seeds might not grow into plants with the same large grains. He needed to be sure that this characteristic was passed on. Longping came up with a plan to breed the plant with other rice plants that had useful characteristics. This way, the seeds would gain the best characteristics from both parents.

China has around 20 percent of the world's population, but only nine percent of the world's land on which to grow crops.

Hybrid rice was born

